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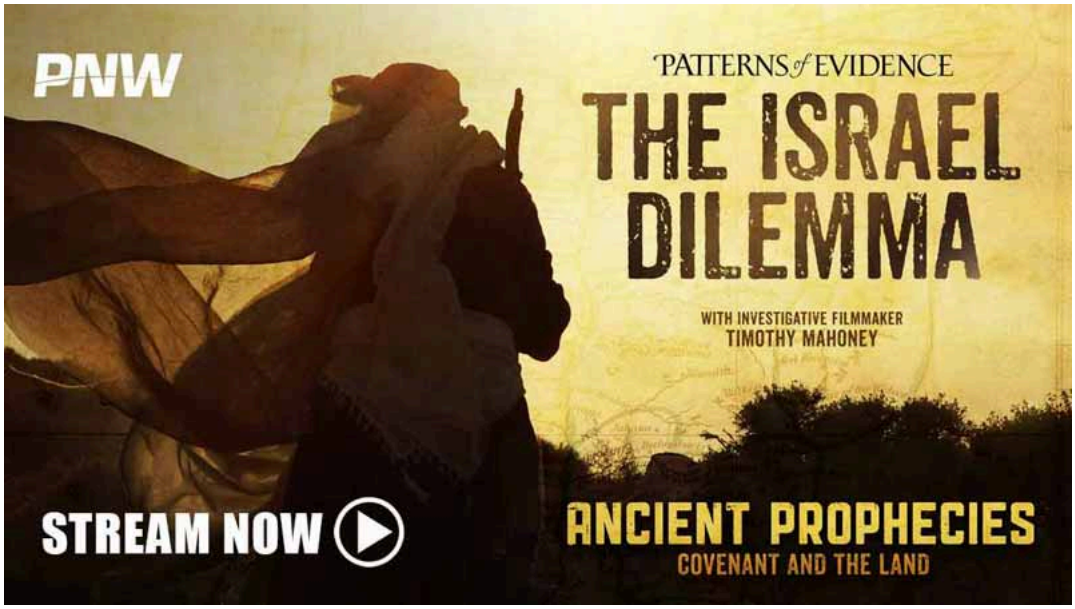

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ARTICLE

One In Twenty Deaths: Canada's Assisted Suicide Program Reaches Stunning Levels

BY PNW STAFF MARCH 13, 2026

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As Canada approaches the 10th anniversary of legalizing assisted suicide, the country is rapidly nearing a grim milestone: 100,000 deaths through the practice.

Based on current trends, the government's "Medical Assistance in Dying" (MAiD) program has become one of the leading contributors to deaths nationwide. Since legalization in 2016, the number of Canadians who have died through assisted suicide has risen dramatically year after year, placing Canada on track to become the first modern nation to surpass 100,000 euthanasia deaths in less than a decade.

The scale of the program is staggering. In 2024 alone, 16,499 Canadians died through MAiD--about 5.1 percent of all deaths in the country, meaning roughly one out of every twenty deaths in Canada now occurs through assisted suicide.

At the current pace--about 45 assisted deaths every day--Canada is expected to pass the 100,000 mark around the June anniversary of the law's passage.

The number has gained renewed attention following warnings from Kelsi Sheren, a Canadian anti-MAiD activist and military veteran, who argued that the system has drifted far from what Canadians were originally promised.

"MAiD was sold as a narrow option for the terminally ill, a rare mercy," Sheren wrote in a recent op-ed. "That fiction collapsed long ago. Today, assisted death is a routine outcome for people struggling with disability, isolation, poverty, and mental health challenges--and when the world looked at what we're doing, it didn't nod approvingly. It recoiled."

From "Last Resort" To Expanding System

Assisted dying was legalized by Parliament with the passing of Bill C-14 on June 17, 2016. The law allows adults to seek MAiD if they suffer from a "grievous and irremediable medical condition," are in an irreversible decline, and experience suffering they deem intolerable.

Originally framed as a compassionate option for those facing imminent death, the law has gradually expanded through court rulings and legislative changes.

In 2021, Canada broadened eligibility through Bill C-7, creating a second category for people whose natural death is not reasonably foreseeable. Since that change, the number of non-terminal cases has steadily increased each year.

Under current law, mental illness alone is not yet an eligible condition. However, legislation passed in 2024 delays but still anticipates that mental illness could qualify for euthanasia beginning March 17, 2027, if certain training and safeguards are implemented.

Critics warn that such expansions could further normalize assisted death in situations far removed from terminal illness.

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Cases Raising Alarm

Concerns intensified following the case of Kiano Vafaeian, a 26-year-old Canadian suffering from Type 1 diabetes, vision problems, and seasonal depression, who ended his life through the MAiD program in December 2025.

His family says they were shocked that doctors approved the request.

"We never thought there would be a chance that any doctor would approve a 22- or 23-year-old at that time for MAiD because of diabetes or blindness," his mother said.

Cases like Vafaeian's have fueled growing debate over whether vulnerable individuals--including those facing disability, chronic illness, or emotional distress--are being steered toward death rather than receiving greater medical or social support.

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Canada Far Ahead Of The World

Canada's numbers dwarf those of other nations with legalized euthanasia.

Switzerland, which has permitted assisted suicide for roughly two decades, has recorded fewer than 9,000 deaths from the practice. Belgium has experienced roughly 33,000 deaths across more than 20 years.

Even in the United States--where assisted suicide is legal in several states--the total number of deaths across more than two decades is estimated at just over 5,000.

Only the Netherlands has a higher share of deaths by euthanasia, with roughly 5.8 percent of all deaths, compared with Canada's 5.1 percent. Yet Canada's rapid rise in absolute numbers has stunned many observers.

Some analysts now say Canada has become the fastest adopter of euthanasia in the world, reaching levels that took other countries far longer to achieve.

A Profound Ethical Turning Point

Supporters of MAiD argue the program offers compassionate relief for those enduring unbearable suffering and preserves personal autonomy at the end of life.

But opponents--including disability advocates, religious leaders, and medical ethicists--warn that Canada may be crossing a dangerous threshold where assisted suicide becomes normalized within healthcare itself.

What began as a narrow exception for extreme end-of-life suffering is increasingly viewed by critics as a broader social solution to pain, disability, and despair.

As Canada approaches its 100,000th assisted death, the country is confronting a sobering question:

Is this the fulfillment of compassionate medicine--or the quiet redefinition of how a society values life itself?

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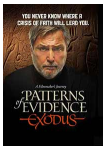

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